

Question ID: 1a61e2ae

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

English poet and Shakespeare contemporary John Donne’s _____ much admired during his lifetime (1572–1631) and in the decades that followed, had, at the time of their enthusiastic rediscovery by the early twentieth-century modernists, been essentially gathering dust for the intervening 250 years.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. works were
- B. works, were
- C. works,
- D. works had been

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation and verb forms within a sentence. This choice leaves the verb "admired" in its nonfinite past participle form to function within a supplementary element ("much...followed"). Offset by commas after "works" and "followed," this supplementary element interrupts the main clause ("English poet and Shakespeare contemporary John Donne’s works...had...been essentially gathering dust...") with additional information about the works’ reception during Donne’s lifetime.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to offset the supplementary element ("much...followed") with appropriate punctuation, and using the finite verb "were much admired" results in an ungrammatical sentence. Choice B is incorrect because using the finite verb "were much admired" results in an ungrammatical sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to offset the supplementary element ("much...followed") with appropriate punctuation, and using the finite verb "had been much admired" results in an ungrammatical sentence.